

these are similar. You will need to crop the image, add layers, effects and text to the image. The same approach can be used to make any other kind of personal graphics, such as a blog header or image macros.

To crop an image, use the rectangular selection tool (1) and select the area of the image that you want to use. Next, cut the portion of the image and create a new file. Paint.net will automatically use image dimensions according to the area cropped. Alternatively, once the selection is made, you can use [Ctrl] + [Shift] + [X] or Image > Crop to Selection for the same result. You now have the base image. You might want to modify the base image, and adjust the image properties.

Levels correct the balance of the shadows and highlights in an image. This operation might make the image grainier, but as these images are meant to be small, the change will not be very apparent. Go to Adjustments > Levels and slide the Output histogram slider upwards or downwards till you have a better looking image. Adjustments > Brightness / Contrast is another great setting to play around with. Try high contrast and low contrast variations, till you arrive at a base image that you like.

Now, you may or may not want to add effects to the image. These effects will dramatically change the look of the image. Go to Effects > Artistic > Oil-Painting, which is just one of the many effects or filters you can apply to the image. Next, duplicate the base layer and go to Layer > Layer Properties. Change the Mode of the blending, and experiment with the transparencies. There are some options in the Layer blending menu that is not available in Photoshop. We liked the way the “glow” blending looked, so we used that. Alternatively, you can add another image to the layer, and blend it in to the first layer.

Next we need some effects and artwork around the image. Go to Layer > Add new layer. Select vector shapes or other graphics that you might like. We will use the fractal engine to create some fractals and overlay it on the image. Go to Effects > Render > Mandelbrot Fractal. Change the settings till you get a fractal that